

loyees.

1. Use inclusive and gender-neutral language in all writing.
1. Always write "GitLab" with "G" and "L" capitalized, even when writing "GitLab.com", except within URLs. When "gitlab.com" is part of a URL, it should be lowercase.
1. Do not use a hyphen when writing the term "open source" except where doing so eliminates ambiguity or clumsiness.
1. If an email needs a response, write the answer at the top of it.
1. Use the future version of words, just like we don't write internet with a capital letter anymore. We write frontend and webhook without a hyphen or space.
1. Our homepage is <<https://about.gitlab.com/>> (with the about. and with https).
1. If you use headers, properly format them (in Markdown, "Heading 2" in Google Docs); start at the second header level because header level 1 is for titles. Do not end headers with a colon. Do not use emoji in headers as these cause links to have strange characters.
1. Do not use acronyms when you can avoid them. Acronyms have the effect of excluding people from the conversation if they are not familiar with a particular term. Example: instead of MR, write merge request (MR).
1. If acronyms are used, expand them at least once in the conversation or document and define them in the document using Kramdown abbreviation syntax. Alternatively, link to the definition.
1. If you don't know the meaning of an acronym, ask. It's always ok to speak up.

Communicating dates and time

1. For external content, refer to the guidance in the GitLab Content Style Guide.
1. For internal content, use ISO dates: yyyy-mm-dd
1. For months, use yyyy-mm, so 2018-01 for January.
1. Refer to a year with CY18 (never with 2018) and a quarter with CY18-Q1 to prevent confusion with fiscal years and quarters. If the year is obvious from the context it is OK to use Dec 4, but not 12/4.
1. GitLab operates on a Fiscal Year offset from the calendar year. When referring to a fiscal year or quarter, please use the following abbreviations:
 1. "FY20" is the preferred format and means: Fiscal Year 2020, the period running from February 1, 2019 through January 31, 2020
 1. "Q1" = the first quarter of the current Fiscal Year, so on Feb 1, 2020, "Q1" is the period from Feb. 1, 2020 through April 30, 2020. Note that Epics in GitLab follow Calendar Years and Quarters.
 1. When referring to a quarter in a future or past year, combine the two above: "FY21-Q1"
 1. When financial data is presented, include a note to indicate fiscal year (e.g. "Fiscal Year ending January, 31 'YYYY')
1. For time formatting guidelines, refer to the GitLab Content Style Guide.
1. Please remember that not everyone is working in the same timezone; what may be morning for you is evening for someone else. Try to say 3 hours ago or 4 hours from now, or use a timestamp, including a timezone reference.
1. Don't use "EOD" or "end of day" ("COB" or "close of business", "EOB" or "end of business"), unless you are okay with a deliverable being due at the end of anywhere on earth. Team members communicate across timezones, where "end of day" does not specify the exact date and time. When you want something due at a specific time, communicate the date and time by when the request should be done, for example: Please review before 2023-06-10 5PM PT.

Visuals

Many times an explanation can be aided by a visual.

Whenever presenting a diagram, we should still allow everyone to contribute.

Where possible, take advantage of the handbook's support for Mermaid. If you are new to using Mermaid or need help troubleshooting errors in your Mermaid code, the Mermaid Live Editor can be a helpful tool.

Where taking advantage of Mermaid isn't possible, link to the original in our Google Drive so that the diagram can be edited by anyone.

Ubiquitous language

At GitLab we use ubiquitous language to increase communication efficiency.

This is defined in Domain-driven design as: "A language structured around the domain model and used by all team members to connect all the activities of the team with the software."

We use it for activities in GitLab, even ones not implemented in software.

By having ubiquitous words to identify concepts we prevent confusion over what is meant, for example we refer to parts of our organization as a function, department, or group depending on exactly what is meant.

Make sure that domains don't overlap, for example organization size and deal size don't reuse words to prevent overlap.

If a term is ambiguous don't use it, for example our hiring team uses the terms roles and vacancies, but avoid the ambiguous word job.

Make sure that projects and working groups have clear and direct names. Prefer "CI Spend Reduction Working Group" to "Project Raven Working Group".

Make sure that people can infer as much as possible from the word, for example our subscription options allow you to know if someone is using self-managed or GitLab.com.

Make sure terms don't overlap without clearly defining how and why, for example see our tier definitions.

Keep terms to one or at most two words to prevent people from introducing ambiguity by shortening a term. When using two words make the first word unique because people tend to drop the second word more often.

MECEFU terms

MECEFU is an acronym for Mutually Exclusive Collectively Exhaustive Few words Ubiquitous-language.

You pronounce it: MessiFu. Think of the great soccer player Lionel Messi and his kung fu or soccer fu skills.

We want to use MECEFU terms to describe a domain to ensure efficient communication. MECEFU terms have 4 characteristics that help with efficiency:

- 1. Mutually Exclusive: nothing is referenced by more than one term
- 1. Collectively Exhaustive: everything is covered by one of the terms
- 1. Few words: the longer terms are the more likely it is people will not use all of them and cause confusion, therefore consider two words as the upper limit for a single term. Avoid acronyms because they are hard to remember (we're open to a few words to replace MECEFU as an acronym :)
- 1. Ubiquitous language: defined above

An example of a MECEFU term is our sales segmentation:

- 1. Mutually Exclusive: There is no overlap between the numbers and there is a single dimension.
- 1. Collectively Exhaustive: Everything for 0 to infinite employees is covered.
- 1. Few words: Mid-market is a natural combination and SMB is abbreviated.
- 1. Ubiquitous language: We're not using the word 'Enterprise' which already can refer to our Enterprise Edition distribution.

One nit-pick is that the Medium of SMB and Mid of Mid-Market sound very similar.

Simple language

Simple Language is meant to encourage everyone at GitLab to simplify the language we use. We should always use the most clear, straightforward, and meaningful words possible in every conversation.

Avoid using "fluff" words, jargon, or "corporate-speak" phrases that don't add value.

When you don't use Simple Language, you:

- Confuse people and create a barrier for participants of your conversation.
- Cause others to not speak up in a meeting because they don't understand what you're saying.
- Are not inclusive of those whose first language is not English.
- Do not add value with your words.

When you do use Simple Language, you:

- Get work done more efficiently.
- Build credibility with your audience (your team, coworker, customer, etc.).
- Keep people's attention while you're speaking.
- Come across more confident and knowledgeable.

Here's an example:

Original sentence

> We're now launching an optimization of our approach leveraging key learnings from the project's postmortem.

A Simple Language sentence

> We're creating a new plan based on what we learned from this project.

Simple Language is important both when we're speaking to other team members and when we're representing GitLab to people outside the company.

Be sure to use Simple Language in written communications as well.

Our handbook, website, docs, marketing materials, and candidate or customer emails should be clear, concise, and effective.

Corporate marketing maintains guidelines on GitLab's tone of voice.

Instead of...	Try...	
-----	-----	
Getting buy-in/Getting alignment	Asking for feedback since DRIs make decisions	
Synergy	Effective Collaboration	
Get all your ducks in a row	Be organized	
Do not let the grass grow too long	Work quickly	
Leverage	Use more explicit phrasing- debt, etc.	
Send it over the wall	Share it with a customer	
Boil the ocean	Waste time	
Punt	Make less of a priority	
Helicopter view/100 foot view	A broad view of the business	
Turtles all the way down	Cascade through the organization	
When someone has spare/extra cycles	When someone is available	

Inefficient things shouldn't sound positive

For example, do not suggest that you're "working in real-time" when a matter is in disarray. Convey that a lack of organization is hampering a result, and provide feedback and clear steps on resolving.

Do not use a cool term such as "tiger team" when the existing term of "working group" is more exact. While cool terms such as these may be useful for persuading colleagues to join you in working towards a solution, the right way isn't to use flowery language.

The last example is when we used 'Prioritizing for Global Optimization' for what we renamed to headcount reset. When we renamed it we saw a good reduction in the use of this disruptive practice of moving people around.

Using additional languages

Using American English as our standard language supports our values such as efficiency, results, and transparency.

Careful use of another person's language can be a celebration of diversity and build an atmosphere of inclusion.

The guidance in this section applies to written one-to-one communication, for example, merge request comments between an author and reviewer, not merge request descriptions or commit messages. Also keep the following in mind:

- Use of an additional language is optional.

- Stick to the few simple phrases in the table below.
- Always include the language used and a translation to English.
- Team members can choose to indicate the languages they speak in their Slack profile.
- When in doubt, use American English.

Here's an example:

```
<!-- vale handbook.Spelling = NO -->
> Hey @nmalcolm, I left some suggestions for your merge request. Ka mau te wehi! (Te Reo M·ori:
great work / well done!)
>
> ..... (Japanese: thank you very much) for the review @cynthia!
```

Language	Hello	Thank you	Great work / well done
Croatian	Hvala		
Japanese			
Te Reo M·ori	Kia ora	Ng· mihi	Ka mau te wehi!

```
<!--
```

Note to table contributors:

- Keep the list in alphabetical order
- Provide guidance when required, e.g. regarding plurals, formality, gender. If possible provide simple language that is suitable for all circumstances.
- Provide a template if the placement of a person's name is important, e.g. "Kia ora NAME".

```
-->
```

```
<!-- vale handbook.Spelling = YES -->
```

Avoid using Git in Project Names

Avoid using Git in the naming of internal and external company related programs (BagGit, GitFit, Gitty, GitIt, etc.). Referencing Git creates an inaccurate perception that GitLab has a narrow focus. While GitLab started as a source control platform, it has become The DevOps Platform.

Email

We have a low internal email culture, as we see greater efficiency in other forms of communication (e.g. Slack). If you are emailing, please use the following guidelines:

1. Send one email per subject as multiple items in one email will cause delays (have to respond to everything) or misses (forgot one of the items).
1. Always reply to emails by replying to all, even when no action is needed. This lets the other person know that you received it. A thread is done when there is a single word reply, such as OK, thanks, or done.
1. If you're sending an email to a large group of people (or a distribution list), put those recipients in BCC (rather than in the "To" field) so that a reply all won't ping hundreds of people.
1. If you forward an email without other comments please add FYI (for your information), FYA (for your action), or FYC (for your consideration). If you forward an external request with FYC it just means the person who forwarded it will not follow up on the request and expects you to

decide if you should follow up or not, the terms comes from movie promotion to voters>).

1. Email forwarding rules are specified in the shared Email, Slack, and GitLab Groups and Aliases Google Doc accessible only to people in the company. If you want to be added or removed from an internal alias, change a rule, or add a forwarding email alias, please suggest an edit in the doc and submit a new access request.

1. Only Google Workspace domain admins are allowed to provision Google Groups and email distributions.

1. Emails are asynchronous, for example, if your manager emails you on a weekend it is fine to reply during the workweek.

1. If an email is or has become urgent feel free to ping people via chat referencing the subject of the email.

1. If you or your team needs to send an email to a group of team members, not grouped in a current Google email group, and specifically related to personally identifiable information (location, state, country, etc.) please contact a Total Rewards Analyst at total-rewards@gitlab who can create an email list from Workday data, with approval.

1. Where appropriate, consider using professional salutations including Hi or Hello and avoid colloquial expressions such as Hey, Oh, or Sup. Sometimes only the person's name is suitable. The level of formality should often mirror the formality from previous messages when communicating with internal team members as well as external persons.

1. Try to always use a person's name when starting or responding to a message, especially if there are multiple persons cc'd, so that the addressee knows you are addressing them.

1. Make sure all relevant letters and words that need capitalization are capitalized, such as the start of sentences or the word "I".

1. Proofread your messages so that sentences are punctuated correctly, typos are fixed, and grammar is corrected. Consider using the really helpful Grammarly tool - this tool is great for both native English speakers and for those who use English as an additional language.

1. All messages and replies are signed with a professional send-off (ex. Best regards), your name, and your signature block.

Slack

Slack is used for:

- Internal-only communication and announcements impacting all team members
 - Linking a GitLab Issue or Merge Request (confidential if necessary) where discussion can take place is encouraged when sharing announcements on Slack
 - Consider creating a Manager Mention MR, so that we can collaborate with Efficiency and Transparency across threads
- Company newsletters and team updates
- Asynchronous team standups, questions, and quick collaboration
- Informal communication

Use a bias for action to quickly move conversations that require collaboration and action out of Slack and into an issue.

Only 90 days of Slack activity will be retained, so Slack should specifically NOT be used for:

- Obtaining approvals
- Documenting decisions
- Storing official company records or documents

- Sharing personal or sensitive information regarding any individuals

Internal Slack messages between team members are still considered professional communication. Please do not use or add emoji's to Slack that are of a political, religious or of a sexual nature. You can refer to the Religion and politics at work section of the handbook. When in doubt do not use or add the emoji. If you have any concerns about an emoji that was used, please reach out to the author or if you are not comfortable doing so please reach out to your People Business Partner.

There is a lot of information pertaining to Slack, as it is a critical part of GitLab's communication. See the Slack tools and tips page.

General guidelines

1. Everyone can contribute, and while opinions are important to provide perspective, we value proposals and iteration. If the subject is of value to the wider community, consider commenting on an existing issue or opening a new merge request instead.
1. Use the :whitecheckmark: emoji or similar to indicate an inquiry has been answered. Anyone can add the emoji. If you're not sure, then feel free to leave it up to the person who asked. An emoji indicator is particularly helpful in channels where lots of questions are posted, such as questions, and git-help.
1. In general, you can think of emoji reactions as equivalent to body-language responses we use in real-life conversations, such as nodding your head as encouragement when a verbal (or in Slack, written) response might be too much. However, please be aware that use and understanding of emoji, like body-language, is not universal. Others may not communicate via those means the same way that you do, particularly those who are Autistic or otherwise neurodivergent. If in doubt, you can use text to clarify.
1. In both public and private channels, threads are valuable for keeping conversations together. If you want to respond to a question or comment in a channel, please start a thread instead of responding below them in the channel. This helps to keep the discussion in one place where it is easy to follow, and reduces noise as each message in a thread does not result in an unread message for everyone in the channel.
1. Unless you're in an active chat, don't break up a topic into multiple messages as each one will result in a notification which can be disruptive. Use threads if you want to provide extra info to the question/comment you posted.
1. If you are having a hard time keeping up with messages, you can update your preferences to have Slack email you all notifications. To change the setting, go to Preferences > Notifications > When I'm not active on desktop... and "send me email notifications."
1. If you agree in a message to start a video call (typically by asking "Call?") the person that didn't leave the last comment starts the call. So either respond to the "Call?" request with a video link or say "Yes" and let the other person start it. Do not say "Yes" and start a call 5 seconds later since it is likely you'll both be creating a video call link at the same time.
1. As an admin of the Slack workspace, if given the option to "Disable future attachments from this website" when removing an attachment from a message this will block the link/domain from unfurling in the entire Slack workspace. Be careful and deliberate when choosing this option as it will impact every user in the workspace.
1. When referencing a Slack thread in a GitLab.com issue, don't only link to the thread. Not only will people outside of the GitLab organization be unable to access the content, but the link will expire after the Slack retention period expires. Instead:

1. Review the contents for confidentiality of users, customers, or any other sensitive information before posting.

1. Copy and paste the relevant parts of the thread into the issue using blockquote formatting.

1. Link to the Slack thread and include (internal) after the link. For example:

<https://gitlab.slack.com/archives/C0AR2KW4B/p1555347101079800> (internal)

1. Post a link to the issue note in the Slack thread to let others know that discussion has moved to the issue.

1. When selecting your Slack display name, please do not have your name in all capital letters as this is often associated as shouting in written communications.

Avoid direct messages

Note: We don't use the term private message, because these direct messages are not inherently private like a phone call or private letter. The messages are potentially accessible by Workspace admins or via Backups. Slack refers to these types of messages as direct messages themselves.

When using Slack for work-related purposes, please avoid direct messages. Direct messages discourage collaboration. You might actually be contacting the wrong person, and they cannot easily redirect you to the right person. If the person is unavailable at the moment, it is less efficient because other people cannot jump in and help. Use a public channel and mention the person or group you want to reach. This ensures it is easy for other people to chime in, involve other people if needed, and learn from whatever is discussed.

If someone sends you a work-related direct message, it is okay to let them know you'd like to take the conversation to a public channel, linking to this section of the handbook. The process might look something like:

- In the direct message: Thanks for reaching out, that's a great question/idea I think the rest of the team could benefit from. I'm going to move this to public-channel based on our desire to avoid direct messages
- In the appropriate public channel: @Person asked "question" in a DM, pulling that out here if anyone else has input.
- Answer the question in a thread on that channel message, allowing others to benefit.

If you find yourself getting a lot of direct messages that should go in a public channel, consider changing your Slack status to an attention grabbing emoji and set it to something like:

- Please consider posting in a public channel before direct messaging
- Why direct message me when you can post in a public channel?

If you must send a work-related direct message, don't start a conversation with "Hi" or "Hey" as that interrupts their work without communicating anything. If you have a quick question, just ask the question directly, and the person will respond asynchronously. If you truly need to have a synchronous communication, then start by asking for that explicitly, while mentioning the subject. e.g., "I'm having trouble understanding issue x, can we talk about it quickly?".

Do not use group direct messages

Use private channels instead of group direct messages. Group direct messages are very hard to maintain, track, and respond to. They also have a key limitation in that you can't add people to the conversation. This is a hindrance to collaboration and transparency.

Consider whether the conversation can take place in a public channel. If not, please use a private channel instead. This channel may have a short-term purpose. It is acceptable to leave the channel and/or archive it if you are no longer an active participant or the channel is no longer in use.

As we grow headcount, we exponentially increase the lines of communication- 3 people have 3 communication lines, 4 have 6, and 41 have 820.

As a result, there is a natural tendency for people to prefer private channels of communication.

The intentions are good, as people are looking to reduce noise for others, but this can lead to the same problems as described elsewhere on this page, notably:

- Communication is siloed.
- As we grow, people may be reaching out to the wrong person.
- If you have a question, other people might have it too.

Slack is our primary source of chat communication and is where many personal interactions happen.

We want to continue to encourage folks to build personal relationships with one another which will often happen over DMs.

Use public channels

- If you use Slack and plan to message 3 or more people, we recommend a channel for customer/issue/project/problem/partnership.
- Learn about common channels and channel-naming conventions.
- If something is important but not urgent - like complimenting or encouraging the entire team - use email or post in the channel without @-mentioning the team.
- It's not rude to leave a channel. When you've had your questions answered or are no longer interested, feel free to leave the channel so it won't distract you anymore.
- The usage of ChatBots for integrations can sometimes depend upon the name of the channel. You should consult the channel about such integrations before changing the name of commonly used/popular channels to avoid inadvertently breaking integrations.

Be respectful of others' time

Start by understanding what we mean by respecting time. We should err toward putting material into channels over DMs and public channels over private channels even though we understand that this will generate more messages that can be read by more people. Respecting time is not about reducing the overall volume of channel messages that team members receive. It's about making sure that messages are targeted, expectations for asynchronous responses are clear, and we are communicating with consideration.

The following tips provide ways to work respectfully with others given this context, though is not an exhaustive list:

- If you're only referring to someone, but don't actually need their attention, and want to spare them from getting notified, spell out their name normally without @ mentioning them.
- You also do not need to @ mention someone if they are part of a Slack thread unless you need their attention (for them to review, respond, etc.), since Slack has a dedicated view for threads.
- Slack messages should be considered asynchronous communication, and you should not expect an instantaneous response; you have no idea what the other person is doing.
- Do not feel obligated to respond to Slack messages when you are not working.
- Feel free to send a colleague a link to these guidelines if the communication in Slack should be done asynchronously.
- Please avoid using @here or @channel unless this is about something urgent and important. In chat, try to keep the use of keywords that mention the whole channel to a minimum. They should only be used for pings that are both urgent and important, not just important. By overusing channel mentions, you make it harder to respond to personal mentions promptly since people get pinged too frequently. Additionally, if you are planning to @mention a specific team (Slack User Group), consider the size of the group you are mentioning (see group membership) and the impact of pinging all of these people for the particular situation. If something is urgent and important:
 - Use @here to notify all currently active members in the room. Please only use @here if the message is important and urgent.
 - Use @channel to notify ALL members in the room, irrespective of away status. Please only use @channel if the message is important and urgent.
- If you are aware that your teammate is on vacation, avoid mentioning them in a high volume channel. It will be difficult to find the information or question when they return. If you need to ensure they refer back to the thread, ensure to send them a link to the relevant Slack message through a direct message.

Questions

If you have a question that you can't find the answer to in our handbook (or you need help finding something in the handbook) team members across the company are here to help. Go directly to the subject matter experts/source in the designated slack channel to ensure your question is addressed.

If your question doesn't relate to any of the existing topics:

- Ask it in the questions Slack channel
- Once you receive an answer, document it in the handbook and post the MR link in your question thread
- :heavycheckmark: once you've been helped

When would GitLab use Corporate Export?

The times this feature would be used would be to comply with certain obligations. Corporate Export must be enabled by Slack in accordance with Slack's policy, which can be found [here](#).

Examples of instances where GitLab may need to use this feature may include, but are not limited to, those situations listed in Slack's documentation.

Are my direct messages and private channel conversations completely private?

No. The Slack Workspace Owner has the ability to export data from all direct messages and private channel conversations for the maximum retention period set by GitLab, which is currently set for 90-days. All messages that are older than 90-days cannot be exported by the Workspace Owner or any other Team Member at GitLab. While messages are not actively monitored, GitLab reserves the right to monitor its software for the reasons stated in its Employee Privacy Policy, including, but not limited to, the safety and protection of our Team Members, the protection of our intellectual property, and the exercise or defense of legal claims.

Please keep GitLab values in mind when communicating directly with other team members. If you have a confidential personal issue that you do not feel comfortable discussing via a business-provided internal communications tool, it is recommended to use a personal form of communication such as a text message or phone call. For additional questions, please address in the issue.

Emergency chat

Slack is down

To use the "Slack Down!" group chat on Zoom:

1. In the Zoom desktop app go to the Team Chat tab
1. Click +
1. Click Join a Channel
1. Search Slack down!
1. Click Join

Once service is restored, go back to Slack.

Zoom is down

To use Slack Huddle:

1. Navigate to the appropriate Slack channel or direct message.
1. Use /huddle to trigger a huddle, which supports both audio and video calls.
1. You may need to give permissions if it's the first time you are using Slack calls.

Once service is restored, go back to Zoom.

Slack and Zoom are down

Join the Slack Down! room on Hangouts Chat.
Once service is restored, go back to Slack and Zoom.

Types of documents

Google Docs

Never use a Google Doc / Presentations for something non-confidential that has to end up on the website or the handbook. Work on these edits via commits to a merge request. Then link to the merge request or diff to present the change to people. This prevents a duplication of effort

and/or an out of date handbook.

Google Docs can be useful when rapidly iterating/commenting/suggesting on the content, but if the content is meant to be long lived it should be moved to the handbook as an SSOT and deprecated with a link to the handbook page. If the content is short lived, e.g. one-time report that won't be referred to beyond 2-3 weeks, it can remain in a Google Doc or presentation.

Pageless is the GitLab preferred format

Google Docs Pageless format is the preferred format for company documents that won't be printed. If you set your default to Pageless then this will be applied to all future documents as well. If a document is likely going to be printed (for example, a contract) the older paged style is acceptable. See Good practices and helpful tips for help navigating the pageless format.

Link sharing

If you do need a Google Doc, create one with your company Google Workspace (formerly G Suite) account and set the visibility, access controls and searchable flag according to the following guidelines.

The recommended defaults when sharing a document for GitLab internal purposes is setting visibility to GitLab, access to Editor and searchable
Can find in search results to ensure everyone can contribute!

Note:

To our knowledge, it is not possible to set the default to Can Edit and you have to change the permissions from View manually. We hope that Google adds this capability in the future.

Visibility Setting	Use Cases
Public	Avoid this setting. Instead, choose GitLab, then explicitly share the document with desired external individuals. Only use this if you want the document to be public but not indexed by Google.
Anyone with the link	GitLab (Recommended Default) This is the recommended default as it allows anyone within GitLab to easily discover documents via searching for their name within Drive.
Restricted	When the document contains highly sensitive or private information such as 1:1s with direct reports
Searchable Setting	Effect
Can find in search results.	makes the file available to anyone with a PeppGitLaberdine Google account and discoverable within GitLab Google Drive's search feature.
Must have link to access	makes the file available to anyone with a GitLab Google account

who has the link. |

Access Setting	Use Cases
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Editor	Anyone that can view the document can edit it. This is the recommended setting when On - GitLab is enabled for the document
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Commenter	Anyone that can view the document can add a comment but cannot edit the document. This is ideal if you want to provide visibility but retain more fine-grained control of document editing.
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Viewer	Individuals with access to the document will only be able to view it.
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Reference Google's documentation on Link Sharing to learn more.

Good practices & helpful tips

1. If you have content in a Google Doc that is later moved to the website or handbook, deprecate the Google Doc.

1. When referring to a Google Doc or folder on the Google Drive in the handbook, refrain from directly linking it. Instead, indicate the name of the doc. If you link the URL people from outside the organization can request access, creating workload and the potential for mistakes. (In the past, linking a Google Doc has led to inadvertently opening the sharing settings beyond what was intended.) This also helps prevent spam from people outside GitLab requesting access to a doc when clicking its link. To save people time you can also link to the search results page which allows people to quickly get to the doc without anyone being able to request access. If there are multiple documents showing up in the search, you may filter your search link by adding the owner.

1. If you are having trouble finding a shared Google Doc, make sure you Search <your domain> in Google Drive.

1. In our handbook, if you find yourself wondering whether it is better to provide a public link to a Google Doc vs. writing out the content on the website, use the following guideline: Is this document frequently adapted / customized? If yes, then provide a link, making sure that the document can be commented on by anyone with the link. For instance, this is how we share our employment contracts. If the document is rarely customized, then provide the content directly on the site and deprecate the Google Doc.

1. If you want to quickly find where a team member's cursor is in a Google Doc, click their icon at the top of the document and the app will jump you to the current location. This works in Sheets and Presentations as well.

1. You can set the notifications on a Google Doc so you only get emailed when someone tags you directly instead of getting emails for every comment. Click on "notifications" and select "Only yours". By the way, when you create the doc, it defaults to All, but when you are just shared with it, it defaults to Only yours. There is no global default.

1. You can find a template of the GitLab letterhead on the shared Google Drive. Please be sure to make a copy of the document to your Google Drive before customizing the template for your use.

1. If you want to have the Google Doc be readable to the public, do not change the sharing settings from 'Editable by Everyone at GitLab', publish the document instead.

1. In all cases, the sharing settings (who a document is shared with, if it is visible to the whole company, etc.) on a Google Doc should be the single source of truth for the confidentiality of the document.

1. Avoid using your initials when adding content to Google Docs or referring to someone else. Use your full name, as Google Docs Smart Compose will auto-complete names for you, and display information about the GitLab team member on hover. It makes documents more readable and consumable, especially for people outside your team/department.

1. When there is a synchronous discussion about an issue or MR captured in a Google Doc, be sure to summarize the discussion into the issue or MR and link to the agenda item where it was discussed with a bookmark. If the notes are limited access or no notes were taken, please say so. This will ensure that interested GitLab Team Members can see both the summary and context of the discussion.

1. In the pageless format you can use `COMMAND+OPTION+SHIFT+J` or `View-->Hide Comments` to quickly hide comments that reduce document width.

1. When using Google Docs, paste full URLs rather than linking text. Chips are the one acceptable alternative when linking to another Google document. Advantages for using URLs rather than hyperlinks include:

1. Greater visibility when it is a long URL and specific. Links are important but easy to miss otherwise (short and only a different color and/or underlined).

1. Ability to see what the content is without hovering over (which isn't quick on mobile).

1. Makes it easier to paste the content as formatting free text (not rich text), which we prefer and is sometimes the only option.

How to deprecate a Google Doc

1. Add 'Deprecated: ' to the start of the title.

1. Remove the content you moved.

1. Add a link to the new location at the beginning of the doc/first slide/first tab.

1. Add a link to the merge request or commit that moved it (if applicable).

Handbook page

Pages like this are part of the handbook. The GitLab handbook is the central repository for how we run the company.

Product documentation

GitLab Docs - docs.gitlab.com is where you can find documentation on GitLab, the product.

GitLab repositories

repository/repositories are where files are kept under source code management. In most cases, requires MRs to merge. The Handbooks are in a repository, our code is in a repository, etc.

READMEs

README - README.md files are what are shown by default when you browse a repository. Contains useful information to give context on what the project/repository are for. These can also be used for user profiles as personal READMEs.

Google Calendar

We recommend you set your Google Calendar access permissions to 'Make available for GitLab - See all event details'. Consider marking the following appointments as 'Private':

- Personal appointments
- Confidential & sensitive meetings with third-parties outside of GitLab
- 1-1 performance or evaluation meetings
- Meetings on organizational changes

There are several benefits and reasons to sharing your calendar with everyone at GitLab:

- Transparency is one of our values and sharing what you work on is in line with our message of "be open about as many things as possible".
- Due to our timezone differences, there are small windows of time when our availabilities overlap. If other members need to schedule a new meeting, seeing the details of recurring meetings (such as 1-1s) will allow for more flexibility in scheduling without needing to wait for a confirmation from the team member. This speaks to our value to be more efficient.

If you add blocks of time spent on recurring tasks to your Google Calendar to remind yourself to do things (e.g. "Check Google Analytics"), consider marking yourself "Free" for those events so that coworkers know they may schedule a meeting during that time if they can't find another convenient time.

Google Calendar Appointment Scheduling

This feature allows you to create a link to an availability schedule that you can send to your customers or coworkers for them to schedule a call according to your availability.

This allows you to only show available spots while keeping your other calls private. This also avoids having to go back and forth between you and other person figuring out what day and time works best for both of you. Since this is a native Google Calendar functionality, there is no need to set up integrations with your calendar like other scheduling tools.

A member of our Customer Success team created a demo video of how to use this feature.

External communication

Key practices to consider during any meeting are listed below.

1. Video Calls - If this is your first time meeting a customer/prospect/partner/etc., turn on your camera when you login to Zoom. This will help to make the customer/prospect feel more comfortable as they are certain your undivided attention is geared towards them.
1. "No agenda, no attenda" - Always have an agenda prepped and ready to go, with the exception of coffee chats. Share this with your audience. Make sure that everything on the agenda is accurate and ask if there's anything missing that needs to be addressed during this call or for the future. When there is no agenda, it translates to you not caring. When sharing agendas with customers and partners it should be called "GitLab + Name Shared Collaboration & Agenda", not

"External Agenda" as that implies there is something the parties are not seeing.

1. 70/30 Rule - Ask open ended questions that leave the audience talking 70% of the time, while you are talking 30% of the time. Please note that this varies based on the type of meeting that you are conducting. Be conscious of what questions need to be asked and to capture those items.

1. Take Notes - Effective note-taking is a valuable skill that will help you retain and recall any important details. Be the person who remembers all the details of your audience's needs.

1. Adapt to Audience Tone - Before going into the business portion of your meeting, evaluate first the tone of the audience. Adapt your tone accordingly in order to appeal to various types of personalities.

1. Mid-call - Half-way through the meeting, check in with your audience. Ask them what their thoughts are on the progression of this meeting and if what you're presenting is on the right track. This helps both you and the audience by re-aligning expectations and making sure the meeting is going the right direction.

1. Pre-Close Summary - 10 Minutes (1-hour meetings) or 5 minutes (30 minute meetings) prior to ending the call, ask the audience to build out an agenda for the next step or meeting. This helps to secure next steps and to ensure there are no balls dropped.

1. Post Meeting Action - Immediately write down notes and next steps and input into the proper directory (Google Drive, Salesforce, etc.).

1. Two Block Rule - For in person meetings with external parties you should wait until you're more than two blocks from the meeting before discussing the results of the meeting. Nobody wants to hear themselves being discussed in the bathroom.

Communicating with media and industry analysts

GitLab team members are not authorized to speak with the media or analysts on behalf of our company unless authorized by our Marketing department. Unless authorized, do not give the impression that you are speaking on behalf of GitLab in any communication that may become public. This includes posts to online forums, social media sites, blogs, chat rooms, and bulletin boards. This policy also applies to comments to journalists about specific matters that relate to our businesses, as well as letters to the editor and endorsements of products or services.

For more, please visit the Corporate Communications handbook section.

Paid external speaking requests

GitLab as the leader in all remote work creates opportunities for our team members to receive requests from external 3rd parties to participate on panels, blogs or news publication or articles. Recently our team members have been approached by external 3rd parties looking to pay or compensate GitLab team members for their time to discuss GitLab remote practice to help them guide a client. Other third parties may contact GitLab team members to provide subject matter expertise that they may have by virtue of their role at GitLab. As in any request we ask that team members verify who they are speaking with to make sure the source is indeed a valid and legitimate request. Always remember that you represent GitLab and if any question makes you uncomfortable or gives you a pause on whether you should answer then we recommend that you do not answer. A third party's questions regarding GitLab financials, sales, compliance, executives or specifically where the company is heading should be treated with the most caution. We want and encourage all team members to be remote evangelists and this can be done without giving very specific information about GitLab. If you have any concern about a request please reach out on slack to external-comms

Social media

Please see our team member social media policy.

Posting or streaming to YouTube

See the YouTube page for options and instructions for posting recordings and live streaming to our YouTube channels.

Guidelines for vendor meetings

1. We request external vendor meetings to use our video conferencing tool so we can quickly join the call and record the session if we need to. Confirm with vendor that they agree we can record the call. The DRI for the vendor meeting will generate the zoom link and share with the vendor.

1. Decide ahead of the meeting who should be invited, i.e. those likely to get the most out of it.

1. Ahead of the meeting, we should agree internal agenda items/requirements/priorities and provide to the external provider.

1. In order to make the best use of time, we wish to avoid team introductions on the call, particularly where there are a number of us attending. We can include a list of attendees with the agenda and give it to the vendor before or after the meeting. Introductions can be helpful in some external calls. In those meetings, use these guidelines.

1. When a question or issue is raised on the agenda, if the person who raised it is present they will verbalize it live on the call; or if they are not present, then someone will raise it for them. This is a common GitLab practice.

1. Where possible, we request that the vendor provides their slides / presentation materials and any other related information after the meeting.

1. Do not demo your tool live, create a pre-recorded walk-through of the tool and make it available to GitLab before the meeting so we can ask questions if needed.

1. Be cognizant of using inclusive language.

1. We respectfully request that everyone is mindful of the time available, to help manage the call objectives effectively.

User communication guidelines

- Keep conversations positive, friendly, real, and productive while adding value.

- If you make a mistake, admit it. Be upfront and be quick with your correction. If you're posting to a blog, you may choose to modify an earlier post. Just make it clear that you have done so.

- There can be a fine line between healthy debate and incendiary reaction. Try to frame what you write to invite differing points of view without inflaming others. You don't need to respond to every criticism or barb. Be careful and considerate.

- Assume positive intent and explicitly state the strongest plausible interpretation of what someone says before you respond, not a weaker one that's easier to criticize. Rapoport's Rules also implores you to list points of agreement and mention anything you learned.

- Answer questions, thank people even if it's just a few words. Make it a two way conversation.

- Appreciate suggestions and feedback.

- Do not make promises that you can't keep.

- Do not offer platitudes. Be direct and respectful. For example - we don't need to suggest

that our actions are because we "heard feedback" when they are really done for other reasons.

- Guide users who ask for help or give a suggestion and share links. Improving Open Development for Everyone, Types of requests.
- When facing negative comments, respond patiently and treat every user as an individual, people with the strongest opinions can turn into the strongest supporters.
- By default, discussions in issues and MRs are public and could include participation of wider community members. It is important to make the wider community members feel welcome participating in discussions and sharing their view. Wider community members also submit MRs to help improve our website/handbook and this is often their first contribution to GitLab. We want to make sure that we are responsive to their contributions and thank them for helping improve GitLab.
- Adhere to the Code of Conduct in all communication. Similarly, expect users to adhere to the same code when communicating with the GitLab team and the rest of the GitLab community. No one should accept being mistreated.

Company phone number

If you need to provide the details of GitLab's contact information you can take the address from the visiting page for reference; or the mailing address of the office in the Netherlands if that is more applicable.

If a phone number is required, leave this field empty by default. If that is not possible, then use

the general number (+1-415-761-1791), but be aware that this number simply guides to a voice message that refers the caller back to contacting us via email.

Effective communication competency

Competencies are the Single Source of Truth (SSoT) framework for things we need team members to learn.

In an all-remote organization effective communication is key to exchanging knowledge, ideas, and information. Effective communication at GitLab:

- Uses asynchronous communication as the starting point and stays as open and transparent as we can by communicating via text through public issues, merge requests, and Slack channels (over DMs).
- Places an emphasis on ensuring that conclusions of offline conversations are written down ensuring a single source of truth.
- Produces video when necessary.

If you would like to improve your skills or expand your knowledge on topics relating to Communication at GitLab, check out our resources:

- Communicating effectively and responsibly through text
- Embracing asynchronous communication

Skills and behavior of applying effective communication as a Team Member:

- Effectively practices communication via text.
- Uses asynchronous communication when possible: merge requests (preferred) or issues.
- Directs all communication to the appropriate channels (Slack, GitLab, email).
- Recognises when synchronous communication is the more appropriate option.
- Directs all decisions and discussions to the Handbook as a single source of truth.
- Records videos to communicate information when that is the most efficient and effective way to consume the content.
- Employs multimodal communication to broadcast important decisions.
- Practices low context communication and provides as much background as possible when communicating via text to avoid confusion.

Skills and behavior of applying effective communication as a People Manager:

- Implements working asynchronously across teams, departments or across the company. Drives communication where possible to asynchronous channels.
- Holds team members accountable for effectively communicating via text.
- Fosters an environment across teams, departments or divisions where asynchronous communication is the starting point.
- Guides team members on when producing video is appropriate. Implements interactive communication tools across their team, department or the company depending on level.
- Drives and funnels conversations to the right channels across teams, divisions and the company.

SECTION: communication/ally-resources.md

What is an ally?

A diversity, inclusion and belonging "ally" is someone who is willing to take action in support of another person, in order to remove barriers that impede that person from contributing their skills and talents in the workplace or community.

How to be an ally

It is not required to be an ally to work at GitLab. At GitLab it is required to be inclusive. Being an ally goes a step beyond being inclusive to taking action to support marginalized groups. The first step in being an ally is self-educating. This is a page to list resources that GitLab team-members have found helpful in learning how to act as an ally.

Acting as an Ally means·

- Being an advocate for individuals and groups other than your own.
- Standing up, even when you feel scared.
- Transferring the benefits of your privilege to those who lack it.
- Acknowledging that even though you feel pain, the conversation is not about you.
- Willing to own your mistakes and de-center yourself.
- Understanding that your education is up to you and no one else.

GitLab Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging resources

Allies familiarize themselves with GitLab's general DIB content

- Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging page
- Gender and Sexual Orientation Identity Definitions and FAQ
- DIB training
- Unconscious bias

Resources

Here are additional resources on being an ally

- Guide to allyship
- 5 Tips For Being An Ally
- Ally skills workshop. Check out the materials section with a handout PDF (linking to many more resources), slides PDF, videos, and more.
- Why cisgender allies should put pronouns on their name tag

Ally Training

We held a 50 minute Live Learning Ally Training on 2020-01-28. The recording follows along with the slide deck and agenda.

{{< youtube "wwZeFjDc4zE" >}}

SECTION: communication/ask-me-anything.md

Purpose

Ask Me Anything (AMA) meetings are arranged to allow team members the opportunity to learn from and ask questions of our E-Group, Board of Directors, and others groups who would like to host an AMA on a specific topic. AMAs can be arranged for many purposes, including the following:

- Allow team members to meet new leaders joining the company
- Clarify a company-wide initiative or change that requires more discussion
- Allow team members to learn more about current leaders
- Spark insightful discussions
- Initiate a retrospective discussion

Who's Involved

AMA meetings typically include the whole company, and are usually initiated by a leader, team member, or a group of leaders.

They can be initiated by anyone who wants to schedule an AMA, but are typically initiated by one of the following:

- GitLab E-Group Member
- Director + Leaders

- Board Member
- GitLab TMRG group

AMAs do not need to have a host, but there should be a person or people available to answer questions related to the AMA topic.

Occasionally an AMA might be held for a smaller audience. It is encouraged for all AMAs to be open to the full company whenever possible. Occasionally an AMA may not make sense to be sent to the whole company. In those instances, it is still encouraged to add the calendar invitation to the GitLab Team Meetings Calendar as sometimes team members may want to join a call that may not be directly applicable to them. Whenever creating an AMA for a smaller group, be sure to invite the team directly in the calendar invite.

AMA Kick off (best practices when starting an AMA)

This guidance is primarily for the person or people who will be answering questions at a given AMA.

Adding context to the AMA agenda and using the first 1-2 minutes of an AMA to ensure the audience understands how the time will be used has shown to lead to more engaging AMAs.

Ensure the following items are added to the AMA agenda and follow these steps to set your AMA up for success:

- The person or people responsible for answering questions should be listed in the AMA agenda and start the AMA by introducing themselves and their roles at GitLab.
- If a brief explanation about why this AMA is being hosted may help the audience understand the purpose for the session, add a first agenda item that adds context and verbalize that point after introducing yourself.
 - If multiple people will be responding to questions, identify one person to speak about why this AMA is being hosted by adding their name to the agenda item.
- Information about how and where questions can be asked by the audience should be captured in the AMA agenda.
 - For most AMAs, questions will be asked in an agenda doc, if this is the case please share that questions can also be asked in the Zoom chat if the agenda doc cannot be accessed.
 - If sli.do or another platform is being used to ask questions, this should be noted.
- If there is additional context the audience should be aware of to fully participate in the AMA or any documents that provide additional information that the audience should know about, it's a good practice to highlight these things up front by adding them as agenda items.
- After that, onto the first question!

Agenda document recommendations

A lot of team members attend AMAs which can lead to the agenda document becoming overloaded. Since this can mean that notes can't be taken for the discussion, it's recommended that team members add their questions to the document and then close the document unless they're actively taking notes.

Team members who require the written notes in order to participate and/or retain information are encouraged to remain in the document.

If the Google document becomes overloaded, people should add their questions to the zoom chat so that a notetaker or moderator of the AMA with access to the document can copy their questions into the agenda.

For team members who are watching the AMA but don't have questions, consider opening the agenda document to gain any initial context but then closing the document in advance of any discussion.

The intention of this is to make sure we're enabling asynchronous communication by allowing team members not in attendance to read a complete record of the AMA at a later time.

Process for initiating a Reverse AMA

E-Group Initiated

- If an E-Group team member would like a Reverse AMA, they or their EBA will contact an associated TMRG. If there isn't an associated TMRG the E-Group member or EBA will broadcast a message through their Slack channel to see if there is a population of members for the AMA.
- The E-Group member or EBA will create an issue (template to follow) tagging the TMRG Leads or a nominated facilitator for a non-tmrgr AMA (facilitator group to be determined), a DIB Team Member, and Stella Treas (Chief of Staff to the CEO)
- The TMRG Leads will consult with the TMRG membership and accept or reject the request. If accepted the TMRG leads will provide an ideal timeframe for the AMA, ideally within 4 weeks from the date of the request.
- Once accepted the EBA will provide a series of times that are suitable
- The E-Group member or EBA will ensure that there is a Reverse AMA facilitator for the session. (Facilitator Group link to follow)
- The EBA will create a calendar invite and Agenda for the agreed time

Team Member Initiated

- A team member of a particular underrepresented group will create an issue (Template link to follow)
- The team member will tag a DIB Team Member, the E-Group Members EBA and Stella Treas (Chief of Staff to the CEO)
- The E-Group member will review the request, the E-Group member can suggest an alternative member including a direct report to host the AMA or may reject the AMA based on the information provided in the issue.
- If accepted the E-Group EBA will work with the E-Group member or direct report to find a time and date that is suitable.
- The team member will work the EBA to ensure an agenda and facilitator are in place.

Reverse AMA Facilitators

It is near impossible to be an effective facilitator while also being a participant. So if you have been identified as a facilitator but would rather participate in the conversation, we encourage you to ask one of your designated facilitator team members (Facilitator Group link to follow) to take your place.

Before facilitating a session, all facilitators will complete the following steps:

1. Complete the LinkedIn Learning Facilitator Training
1. Complete the LinkedIn Learning Empathy Training
1. Watch the purpose of Reverse AMA's Video (too come)
1. Shadow a current facilitator when they are running and AMA
1. Be shadowed by a current facilitator in your first AMA

Current Facilitators:

Template: "Name" - "Role", Self Identified (Optional):

- Liam McNally - Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging Partner, Self Identified (Optional): CIS gender Man, Gay, Black, No Diverseabilities, Age: 31; Region: APAC
- Amanda Rueda - Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging Advisory Group Member, Self Identified (Optional): CIS gender Woman, Age: 45; Region: NORAM
- Giuliana Lucchesi - People Business Partner, Self Identified (Optional): CIS gender woman; Region: NORAM
- Carolyn Bednarz - People Business Partner, Self Identified (Optional): CIS gender woman; Region: NORAM
- Roos Takken - People Business Partner, Self Identified (Optional): CIS gender woman; Region: EMEA

Reverse AMA Hosts

Every Reverse AMA will be hosted by the Executive Business Partner for the E-Group Leader even when the leader is not an E-Group Member

The Executive Business Partner alignment can be found here

Things to remember:

- Remain impartial
- Ensure the call stays on track
- Keep a track of time
- Ensure that a number of voices are heard, including agenda points

Scheduling a Reverse AMA

AMAs are generally coordinated, scheduled, and planned by the Executive Business Administrator team when an E-Group member is the host. Anytime that an AMA is to be hosted by an executive, VP, or Director at GitLab, it should be arranged and scheduled by that functions EBA. AMAs of Board Members are scheduled by the Staff EBA to the CEO.

Other non-Executive AMAs are scheduled by the People Group - Engagement Team. These AMAs are typically a result of a change that impacts the company as a whole and may often be hosted by multiple leadership members in the company. Whenever there is an open slot in the Group Conversation calendar, the People Group - Engagement Team will reach out to the EBA team to create an AMA.

When scheduling an AMA, be mindful of timezones. Generally it is best to have two AMAs, one for the Americas/EMEA time zone, and one for the APAC time zones.

Once a Reverse AMA takes place, a 15-30 minutes debrief meeting should be scheduled immediately following to ensure there is a timely discussion and DRIs are assigned to all actions.

Immediately should be within the week or following the Reverse AMA for best practices. Understanding there are time zones and schedules to consider. When possible scheduling the debrief ahead of time for immediately following the Reverse AMA would be an effective approach. The debrief template includes the DRI and target to complete and should be updated accordingly.

The debrief should include the People Business Partner, AMA Facilitator and DIB team member. There are times where the Debrief is scheduled with the E-group leader however this is optional and as needed.

Setup

AMA meetings always start with an agenda. Ensure that the agenda document is added to the calendar invite at the initial time it is sent to allow everyone to be involved. All questions and answers should be documented in the agenda to allow those who can not attend to catch up as well as to avoid team members talking over each other.

Whenever possible AMAs should be private or publicly live streamed. Please strive to remain public by default when hosting an AMA unless it is centered around a topic that is not-public

The DIB Team and the EBAs will ensure that each Reverse AMA has the correct team members invited, the DIB team will ask People Operations to run this Report monthly (this is private please request if you need access with your reasoning) to ensure we keep attendees up to date.

Process Once Reverse AMA is Setup

1. Determine all the roles for the call.

- Note taker - this role should be assumed by the Business Partner for that group. If you are the note taker, please reach out to the facilitator to ensure there isn't a concern of confidentiality in the note taker as a presence on the call.
- Facilitator - reach out to the facilitator of